

KINGS, CHIEFTAINS AND WARRIORS

By the time the first identifiable Celtic culture emerged, the Hallstatt Period, the Celts were ruled by kings who were immensely rich; They lived in magnificent fortresses and were buried in great tombs, timber-lined and often of oak wood, under large barrows, with splendid grave goods to assist them in the Otherworld.

The rulers of this society were buried with their chariots, wagons, personal ornaments and jewellery, and utensils containing food and drink.

The poorer classes continued to be buried in simple cremation graves as they had been during the earlier Urnfield period.

Like most early Indo-Europeans peoples, early Celtic society was based on a caste system. At the bottom end there were the menials and producers equivalent to the Sudra and the Vaishya caste in Hindu Society.

Next came the warrior caste, equivalent to the Hindu Kshatriya. Then came the intellectual caste, which included all the "professional" functions --judges, lawyers, doctors, historians, bards and priests of religion--the druids.

These were equivalent to the Hindu Brahmin. Similar caste divisions are found in Greek and Roman society. But the reason to compare to the Hindu system is that it still exists so is a modern equivalent we can compare to.

When we get our first glimpse of Irish society, the Celtic structure had not greatly changed. There was a menial caste which was divided into several sub-classes ranging from prisoners to herdsmen and house servants.

The **celle** was the producer, the basis of the entire society. Above them came the warriors and nobles, the **flaith**, often coming under the title of aire (noble) which is cognate with the Sanskrit word *arya*, freeman. Then came the professional class, originally the **druids**.

At the top of society, among both the ancient Celts on the continent and the later insular Celts, there came the kings and queens. Indeed, there

was a whole range of kings from minor kings who paid allegiance to more powerful kings, to over-kings or high kings.

KINGSHIP AMONG THE CELTS

Now, this concept of kingship in Indo-European meant one who stretched or reached out his hand to protect his people. The very word for king (rix) also meant an act of stretching or reaching. This is still found in modern Irish where righ still means 'to stretch'. The word **rich** in English and most Germanic languages as well as French, also comes from the root word for "exalted, noble and kingly."

Gods with 'long hands', such as Lugh Lamhfhada in Ireland and Dyaus in Vedic literature, are symbolic of the concept of royalty. This symbolism is seen in the story of Eremon, son of Golamh, the progenitor of the Gaels. He had taken an oath that, out of his siblings, he would be the first to land on the shores of Eireann (Ireland). When he saw that his ship was not going to be first, he cut off his hand and threw it on shore. Thus Eremon, in spite of his brother Eber's claims, became, according to the Druid Amairgen, the first high king of Ireland (c500BC).

Ri and rigan remain in the Goidelic languages as words for king and queen, but in Welsh the word for king has changed to **Brennin**. It is argued that this derives from Brigantinos--ie the spouse of Briganti, the goddess known as the "elevated one" (Brigit). and thus reflects the ritual mating of a king with a goddess of sovereignty.

Nine kings of Ireland are said to have cohabited with Medb for she would not allow any king to sit at Tara unless she was joined with him. She is a goddess representing sovereignty.

RITUALS OF KINGSHIP

Kings were regarded as divine. They descended from the gods and usually had to ritually mate with a goddess, a recurring theme in Irish mythology. The traditions of Hindu and Celtic kingship, as seen in early Irish sources, are particularly close and the fortunes of the king were seen as being fundamentally bound to the fortunes of the land.

Ritual marriage took place between the king and the land in various symbolic forms. Rituals and tests were practised in choosing a king.

There were sacred inauguration stones, such as the Lia Fail (the stone of Destiny,) which was known as the Stone of Scone and on which Scottish kings were inaugurated. 2

This was looted from Scotland by Edward I and remained in Westminster Abbey until 1996 when it was returned to Scotland. The teaching was that the inauguration stones for kings and chieftains gave a loud cry if they recognized the foot of a rightful king.

Certain rituals particularly delineate Celtic society as Indo-European. In the bull festival, or tarbhfeis, a bull was slain and a Druid feasted on the flesh and drank of a broth made from the cooked animal. He then went into a meditative trance, while four others chanted over him, and he was thought to receive a vision of the next true king.

Bulls, revered for strength and ferocity and virility, were venerated by all the Celtic peoples. This esteem can be judged from numerous figurines and statuettes and other artwork dating from the 7th cent. BC.

Another ritual mentioned by a Welsh historian is the inauguration ceremony of an Irish king where a mare was ritually slaughtered and the king-elect ate of the flesh of the beast then drank and bathed in a broth made from the carcass.

It was a ritual in which the king sought fertility for himself and his people. This may have symbolized a ritual mating with the horse goddess Epona (Epos, a horse) who came to be adopted even by the Romans. Horse sacrifice also appears in another Indo-European culture, in the Hindu ritual of Asvamedha. (As vā m ā dā)

KINGS AND THE LAW

Cesar suggests that some tribes of the Belgae were familiar with a dual monarchy--two kings sharing the throne. He mentions in particular the tribe of the Eburones. Certainly dual monarchy occurs several times in more recent Irish king lists where brothers often shared the throne. For example Fergus and Domnall, sons of Muirchertach, who ruled in 566

Caesar mentions that some Celtic kings exercised authority on both sides of what is now the English Channel. For example, he refers to ^{Sk 58 on es} Suesiones: "They had been ruled within living memory by ^{Diviciac} Diviciacus, the most powerful king in Gaul, who controlled ~~boy~~ only a large part of the Belgic country, but Britain as well" He appears to have ruled about 100 BC.

The system of kingship which emerges in the ancient Irish Brehon Laws, whereby a king was elected by members of certain aristocratic families; the eldest son did not automatically succeed to his father's throne.

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The Germanic branch of Indo-European adopted a different linguistic concept for kingship. The words ~~König and kenig~~ ¹⁸ are derived from the root gen, a people, a nation, or descent. The meaning is that a king was appointed by virtue of his ancestry.

This ancestry was all-important for the appointment of kings. The Celtic form of kingship seems to be a descendant of the indo-European form, and it survived into the Irish Brehon laws. It was not till the 17th Cent AD that this law system was eradicated from use in Ireland by English colonial law. This was also true in Galatia so was part of the wider Celtic system.

SUCCESSION OF KINGS

Kings did not succeed by primogeniture; that is, the eldest son did not necessarily become the successor of his father. It was necessary for the survival of the people to have a strong man on the throne, strong in mind as well as strength, one who could defend his people against any threat from without or within.

So the man who showed a fitness for the ~~post~~ could be a younger son of the previous king just as well as an elder son. Indeed, he could be a brother of the king, an uncle or cousin or grandson. The choice was usually made within three generations and it was those three generations who usually approved of the choice.

Often, and this emerges in the Brehon Laws, the successor to the king was appointed during the kings' lifetime to prevent dispute.

QUEENSHIP AMONG THE CELTS

There are traces of matrilineal descent among certain Celtic groups.

Bede believed that the Picts, a Brythonic Celtic population of Scotland which becomes absorbed into a Goidelic-speaking homogenous society, had a matrilineal kingship. This, however, is not proven.

If kingship among the Celts was usually patrilineal, how can we account for the appearance of female rulers such as Onomaris^{no maris}, and Boudicca, and for the obviously prominent positions of the archeological finds called the 'vix princess' and the Rheinheim princess' and other women who apparently ruled in their own right.

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It is clear both from grave finds and from reports among the classical writers that women could and did occupy high social positions, even ruling a tribe or, like Cartimandua^{Cartimān dūa}, a confederation of tribes. The Roman historian Tacitus puts these significant words in the the mouth of Boudicca: "This is not the first time that the Britons have been led to battle by a woman."

CERTAINLY IN IRISH LITERATURE QUEEN MEDB WAS THE REAL LEADER OF THE CONNACHT AND HER HUSBAND AILILL DEFERING TO HER DOMINANT PERSONALITY. The geneologies of Ireland and historical accounts mention one female high king, Macha Mong Ruadh^{Macha} (Macha of the Red Hair), recorded as the 76th monarch and daughter of Aedh Ruadh^{A. dh. Ruadh}. She died in 377 BC. and is listed as the only female ruler in the period before Christ.

The Brehon Laws have only one reference to female rulers. This occurs in the Bretha Croidhe^{Croidhe} which contains a list of categories of women who are prominent in society, including a "woman who turns back the streams of war" and is "the ruler of hostages" (those taken in battle)

However, most references to the office of kingship do demonstrate a patrilineal model. One possible explanation for the existence of female rulers lies in the fact that, according to the Brehon Laws, the female heir could inherit full property rights if there were no male heirs. Perhaps, therefore, the woman could also become ruler if there were no male heirs.

The Hallstatt period is divided into 4 sections by archeologists. A and B run from c.1200 BC to @800. It is the third period (800-600BC) that the Iron age begins and it is the time of the rise of the wealthy kings and their rich burial mounds. This was also the time of the building of great fortified settlements.

Around the major burial chambers of the kings have been discovered warrior graves, less wealthy than those of the kings and more numerous, thus demonstrating the rise of a powerful aristocracy to support the kings.

One of the features of the Hallstatt princely graves is that there were no weapons of war, swords and shields, placed within them. In graves of the later La Tene period, swords, helmets, shields and other weapons became common. This seems to imply that the early Celtic kings were not so much warriors as civil leader, but that their descendants were more war-oriented.

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show part of 'man with golden shoes' Pt. I, celtis

Most the graves have been found in continental Europe. Royal graves have not been discovered in such profusion in Britain but this might well be due to prolonged ravaging of sites, grave robbing and building.

The royal graves of the early Celts have certainly show the power of the ancient celtic kings. Interestingly, Ireland has not shown the wagon and chariot burials at all. However, Irish records show that in pre-Christian times there were royal cemeteries in various parts of the country for kings and their families.

The old records also state that kings and chieftains were buried in varied ways, some lying flat, others sitting, but often in a standing posture, arrayed in full battle gear with shield and weapons and with their face turned towards the territories of their enemies.

a few famous rulers

There are a number of rulers mentioned by name but I want to mention

three important ones.

^{Vēr cingēt or īr cēl tīll ūs}
- VERCINGETORIX Son of Celtillus (Great King of Heroes), and who is immortalized in a book by Morgan Llewellyn called ~~Book~~ DRUIDS

He was acknowledged king of an alliance of the Gaulish peoples in their struggle against Caesar. After initial success, forcing Caesar to retreat for the first time in his military career, Vercingetorix's forces were trapped in Alésia and he surrendered.

Taken to Rome, he was kept for years in an underground prison before being ritually slaughtered to celebrate Caesar's triumph over the Gauls.

It is from Caesar, of course, that we know the names of many of the Gaulish kings.

^{cū nō bēl īn ūs}
CUNOBELINUS, the hound of Belenus, made famous by Shakespeare as Cymbeline. He became king about 10 AD and under his rule London grew to prominence as a trading center and Britain became a leading commercial centre.

He never sought Roman friendship but there is no record of his doing anything to excite Roman enmity. He was powerful, issuing his own coinage, like his predecessors, and it was only on his death in about 40 AD that Rome decided to seize its chance and attempt a conquest.

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^{cār ac rā cūs}
Many of the petty British kings had argued against Cunobelinus' son Caractacus being his successor, including Caractacus own brothers. They were joined by another king called ^{Berī cūs} Bericus who went to Rome to persuade the emperor to set them up in his place. Such traitors were the diplomatic excuse Rome needed for the invasion of Britain.

BOUDICCA Is the last I will mention, a famous warrior queen, whose name translates as "victory" and is Latinised as Boadicea, the queen of the Iceni in what is now East Anglia.

In 60 AD, having been provoked by the arrogance of a Roman official who had had her flogged and her two daughters raped, Boudicca led a mass uprising against the Romans. Her initial victories were devastating. She annihilated the 9th Hispania Legion and sacked and destroyed the Roman colonial capital at what is now Colchester and their trading centres at

~~London and St. Albans.~~

However, the Romans were able to re-group and won a devastating victory over the British Celts. Altho Boudicca was never captured, reports had it that she and her two daughters took poison. (PLAY SONG FROM "STONE OF DESTINY") - track 5

SUMMARY OF ROYALTY

In the Northwest fringes of Europe, Celtic kingdoms survived until the late medieval period, altho their conquerors tried to disguise the fact by giving the kings a variety of titles from duke to prince to earl.

The last king of Cornwall seems to have been a Howell who surrendered to Athelstan in 931 AD. James VI of Scotland, on the death of Elizabeth I in 1603, agreed ~~with alacrity~~ to become James I of England.

In 1284, after the death of her royal line, England annexed Wales to the English crown in 1284.

In 1541 Henry VIII made himself king of Ireland and forced the Irish royal families to surrender their titles in a policy called 'surrender and regrant'. The kings had to surrender their title and lands and were then granted the title of "earl" together with some of their land back as a fiefdom from Henry as feudal king.

The O'Neills of Ulster, finally defeated, had to flee abroad where their descendants still live in Spain and Portugal.

It is worth noting that the indigenous Celtic aristocracy of Ireland, whose genealogies mostly date from 12th century records, is one of the most ancient in Europe. Today's surviving heads of the Irish Royal dynasties have a tracable

lineage, accepted by genealogists and heralds going back nearly 2000 years, perhaps longer if we may put some trust in the genealogies of the earlier periods.

However, while the genealogists and heralds accept the genealogies back to the first century AD, they prefer to leave aside the genealogies stretching BC as "unproved", altho not going so far as some scholars who dismiss them altogether.

end half here

CELTIC WARRIORS

The Ancient Celts have been painted by classical writers as savage and making war for no reason at all except the 'fun' of it. As already mentioned, they were seen as barbaric children.

Discerning historians have begun to read the ancient texts more carefully. For example, it is generally accepted that a Celtic horde, for no reason at all, swept down on Rome in July 390BC and attacked it. In fact, the story of Rome's conquest was not that simple.

We learn that one tribe, the ^{Se nō nēs} Senones, had crossed the ^{Ap ēn nī nēs} Apennines in search of new land to settle and had encamped outside the Etruscan city of Clusium. Their leader, Brēnnūs, asked the city to grant them lands on which to settle in peace. However, the city elders viewed the newcomers as a threat and appealed to Rome, which had just exerted its military authority over the old Etruscan empire.

Rome sent three ambasssadors, the Fabii brothers, to negotiate. However, they were young and arrogant and negotiations quickly broke down.

When battle began and one of the Fabii brothers killed a Celtic Cheifton, the celts realized that the supposedly 'neutral' Roman ambassadors were actually fighting for the Etruscans, they broke off the battle and withdrew to discuss this breach of international law.

The Celts were strict believers in law and the role of ambassador was a sacred trust. The Celts were horrified by the Roman's behaviour. They held a council meeting and decided to send their own ambassadors to Rome to lodge a complaint with the Roman senate.

Because the Fabii brothers had high rank as patricians in Rome the senate did not take action but referred the matter to the people of Rome, who approved the senates action, even electing the brothers as military tribunes with counselor powers.

The Celtic envoys, as Livy says, were naturally, and rightly, indignant."

The Celtic ambassadors warned Rome of the consequences. The Senones tribe then marched on Rome to exact retribution, a distance of 130 kilometres from Clusium. They harmed no one on their march to the city. Much to the surprize of the people of the countryside, they passed by, exacting nothing saying they had declared war on Rome and the rest of

the people they regarded as friends.

This scarcely accords with the general view of the mindless barbaric horde which swept down on Rome.

The Senones defeated the Roman army at Allia, in a classic battle and moved on to Rome itself. They occupied the city for 7 months before extracting an apology and a ransom in gold. They then withdrew.

They did not care about forming an empire over the Romans, simply to punish them for a transgression of accepted international behaviour.

So, the image of the Celts as making war for the sake of making war is one we can dispense with.

Like all the Indo-European societies, the Celts did have a warrior caste—the equivalent of the Sanskrit Kshatriya, the Roman equites, etc. which we generally tend to translate as "knights."

The Celts, like other Indo-Europeans, had gods of war; their aristocracy or warrior caste had ostentatious weapons and armaments and took pride in individual heroism.

Ironically, the Etruscans and then the Romans learned a great deal from the advanced weaponry of the Celts. Their own weapons, war helmets and shields, and even their tactics, owed much to Celtic innovations. We know much about Celtic weapons from graves, mainly in eastern and northern Italy. Iron helmets replaced bronze helmets about the 4th Century BC.

The Celts also had better shields than the early Romans, large shields which were a better protective covering for the body. They were often carried by a central handle but no forearm strap. The Celtic shield doubled as an offensive weapon because it not only protected the holder from blows of the enemy but could be turned to strike the opponent as well.

The use of body armour by the Celts has been confirmed by archaeological finds and even by Roman representations of Celts in battle. Indeed, yet another Celtic technical innovation was the invention of chain mail around 300 BC.

However, only Chieftains and kings probably wore them because they

were so labor intensive to make.

Mail shirts became highly prized as spoils of war among the Romans who later adopted the idea in their own army.

CHARIOTS

However, the Celts 'secret weapon' was their use of war chariots and cavalry. The Celtic armies were highly mobile and had developed the use of transport and a transport system (~~which we will discuss later~~)

The name for chariots in Celtic is ^{corrig nbs} **covignos** which actually implied a shared transport. As war chariots were "shared" by the warrior and his charioteer, this is quite acceptable.

Chariots in battle were something new to the Romans. Chariots as war machine had fallen into disuse in the ancient world centuries before the Roman-Celtic collision. The Celts had retained them ^{and} re-developed them in the light of their innovations with working iron.

With stronger wheels and the Celts' ability to open up a transport system, it was easy to move the chariots to where they were needed. As a weapon of war they were used mainly on the flanks with cavalry where they would drive against the enemy at speed for the purposes of causing panic.

Livy admits that in battle often the first Roman lines would be trodden underfoot by the rush of cavalry and chariots. Once the lines were broken the Celts used their chariots as a means of transporting the warriors to their combat positions as foot soldiers, as in Homeric Greece.

When Julius Caesar took his legionaries to Britain, he seemed surprised to find that war chariots were in use there. Caesar confesses that the soldiers of his 7th legion were unnerved by the British chariots.

CAVALRY

The other powerful weapon of the Celtic armies was their cavalry. They even won begrudging admiration from the Romans, who adopted the Celtic horse goddess Epona as an accepted deity of the empire as well as recruiting cavalry regiments from the Celts.

Epona was, in fact, the only Celtic deity they adopted and her feast day

was held in Rome on December 18.

Strabo commented that the best cavalry in the roman army was celtic.

Like chariots, Celtic cavalry combined mobility and staying power for they could fight from horseback or on foot.

Celts fought at the battle of Thermopylae in 279 BC and a good description was given:

To each mounted warrior two servants were attached, who were also skilled riders and had horses. When the cavalry went into battle, the servants remained behind so if a horseman or horse fell, the servant would bring him another horse to mount. If the rider was killed, the servant would mount the horse in his master's place. If both rider and horse wer killed, there was a mounted man ready to take his place. If a rider was wounded, one servant would get him back to the camp and the other would take his place in the ranks.

The Romans borrowed their cavalry tactics from the Celts.

The saddle was evolved among the Celts and these were very intricate. A key technical innovation was the four-pommel saddle. Historians once thought that cavalry could have only a limited effectiveness until the invention of the stirrup. However, in the La Tene period the Celts developed a sadde with a firm seat by means of the four pommels, two behind the rump and one angled out over each thigh. The rider sat in, rather than on, this saddle.

CLOTHING (or the lack thereof)

It seems the Celts wore flashy clothes, colorful tunics dyed and embroidered in many colors and garments which they call Bracae (*Bræ cæ*) (breeches), striped cloaks, fastened with a brach. The Romans adopted the Celtic cloak, hooded and the word derived was 'cowl'.

The Celts liked wearing ornaments to indicate their status in society, such as gold bracelets or the brooches with which their cloaks were fastened. Kings and Cheiftons, together with warriors and women of position, wore gold necklets, usually a torc around their necks.

Sometimes, usually for religious reasons, special bands of Celtic warriors went into battle naked with only a sword and shield. The Greeks also

encountered these naked warriors so one historian commented. that they fight totally naked with no protection except from their shields . Their weapons of defense are, thin spears and long sword.

The ^{G-a S& T}Gaesatae as one group was known, were not a tribe at all but a group of elite professional warriors who fought naked for religious purposes as they believed that it enhanced their martial karma, their spiritual vibrations in battle. This contact with Mother Earth added to their spiritual aura, ensuring rebirth in the Otherworld if they perished in this one.

Part of the root word for Gaesatae was ^{gaisce} which means wisdom, the idea being that a warrior was deemed to be a wise person (at least in this group).

CONCLUSION

The Romans even had lessons to learn from the Celts in terms of battle tactics. Livy mentions that a Sentium the Celtic warriors deployed a testudo (tortoise) - a battle tactic in which fightin men locked their shields together to form an impregnable wall.

Once the Romans had adopted the Celtic shield, for it is clear that such interlocking could not be achieved with the older Roman round shield or Buckler, the "tortoise" became regarded as a Roman battle tactic.

If the Celts were initially able to teach the Romans about warfare, why was it that, with the exception of northern Britain and Ireland, they were eventually defeated and swallowed in the *pax Romana*?

For ~~the~~ the Celts, warfare was a matter of honour which could begin and end in a personal single combat. It was often a matter of individual courage. Generally the Celts were not interested in central authority and discipline. They thought and acted as individuals and were natural anarchists.

In modern times these attributes are seen as laudable. In ancient times, they were the reason for the downfall of the Celtic peoples.

We find that the excuse for many of the invasions of Celtic territory by foreign forces, who then remained, was an invitation from a disgruntled Celtic leader who refused to accept the decision of his fellows. This is how Caesar came to Briton, you recall.

The same internal squabbles, in which the electoral system of the Celtic succession laws ^{were} ~~was~~ challenged, or a deposed king did not accept the ruling of the law, can be seen in many examples throughout Celtic history.

It was the Celtic custom when gathered for battle, for a warrior to step out of the ranks and challenge the most valiant champion among the enemy to single combat, brandishing his weapons, boasting of his deeds and those of his ancestors in order to break the nerve of his opponent. Depending on the results of the combat the entire battle could be decided.

The problem was, in battle against the Romans, that cultural differences resulted in different endings. If a Celt was beaten in single combat, often the Celtic army would accept that the matter had been resolved and fade away.

If a Celt won the combat then the Roman forces did not go away but merely fell on the Celts in fury to exact revenge.

In defeat, the Celtic leaders who had led their people into such extremity would either seek death in combat or commit ritual suicide. This was not at all unusual among the ancient Indo-Europeans. The Roman generals often did the same.. Remember the Queen Boudicca and her daughters did so on her defeat.

There is no extensive evidence of women generally taking part in warfare, altho there is a strong insular celtic tradition of female warriors and queens leading their people in battle. Women lik Boudicca or Cartimandua certainly did command their people in battle during the Roman conquest.

~~We will discuss women much more thoroughly the next couple of weeks.~~

When the Celts did fight as an army, they fought as a tribal group and were divided into septs or subdivisions of the tribe--just as they were at Culloden in 1746. If the model of the Scottish clan army is a model for the ancient Celts, it seems that each sept had an hereditary place in the line of battle.

The "age of choice", when Celtic males came to manhood, was sevnteen, so every male over that age, fit enough to carry arms, would be part of the

regiment of his clan or tribe. The chieftain was automatic commander.

They marched into battle with pipes, drums and voices raised in war songs or battle cries.

Livy describes how the Celts used such noise and tumult to throw their enemies into confusion and terror. "They are given to wild outburst and they fill the air with hideous songs and varied shouts. Their songs as they go into battle, their yells and leavings and the dreadful noise of arms as they beat their shields in some ancestral custom all this is done with one purpose, to terrify the enemy.

All in all, then we see that the Celtic warrior was every bit as sophisticated and well armed, tho perhaps not as well disciplined, as his Greek and Roman counterparts.

*Show 2nd half of "Roman invasion of Britain @ 32 min
Start at 23:25 min into show*